Forest vegetation
Grassland vegetation
Riparian vegetation
Aquatic and semi aquatic vegetation

Forest Vegetation

Champion and Seth (1968) recognized a total of 16 forest types in India, Whereas 9 types of them in Tamil Nadu.

I) Moist Tropical Forests

It is in the warmer plains. It is characterised by very dense, multi-storeyed diverse trees, shrubs, lianas and scrub jungles. These areas experience a high rainfall and dry climate. These are further classified into the following types on the basis of wetness.

1. Tropical wet evergreen forests

This type is found at an altitude of nearly 1500 m on the slopes of hills and mountains .These are also called tropical rain forests or tropical wet evergreen forests, where annual rainfall is more than 250 cm.. Vegetation consists of luxuriantly growing huge trees of more than 45 m in height, shrubs, lianas and abundant epiphytes. The common plants are *Dipterocarpus, Artocarpus, Mangifera, Emblica* and *Ixora.* These forests occur in Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Western Coasts, Anamalai hills and Assam. This type is also found in western ghats of Thirunelveli, Kanyakumari, Anamalai Hills of Tamil Nadu

2. Tropical semi-evergreen forests

This type occurs on the slopes of hills and mountain usually up to 1000 m altitude.The annual rainfall in these forests is between 200 to 250 cm. Vegetation consists of luxuriantly growing evergreen species of giant trees and shrubs. The common tree species are *Terminalia, Bambusa, Ixora, Artocarpus, Michelia, Eugenia,* and *Shorea.* Orchids, ferns, some grasses,and herbs are also dominant. These forest are found in Western Coasts, Eastern Orissa and Upper Assam. This type is also present in Coimbatore, Thirunvelveli and Kanyakumar District of Tamil Nadu

3. Tropical moist deciduous forests

The annual rainfall of these forests is 100 to 200 cm with short dry periods. These are spread over an extensive part of the country. Many of the plants shed their leaves in hot summer. Some are ever green and semi-evergreen. The common plant species are *Terminalia, Grewia, Adina, Melia, Albizzia, Dalbergia* and *Shorea.* The most dominant plants are *Tectona* and *Sal.* These are found in Kerala, Karnataka, South Madhya Pradesh, northern parts of Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Bengal, Orissa and Assam. This type is also present in Kanyakumari, Theni, Gudalur, Dindigul, Madurai and Nilgiris of Tamil Nadu.

4. Littoral and swamp forests

These include beach forests, tidal forests, mangrove forests and fresh water swamp forests.

a. Beach forests

These are found all along the sea coasts and river deltas. These areas have sandy soil which consists of large amount of lime and salts but poor in nitrogen and other mineral nutrients. The rainfall varies from 75 cm to 500 cm with moderate temperature. The common tree species are *Casuarina, Borassus, Phoenix, Pandanus* , *Morinda* and *Thespesia* with many twiners and climbers.

b. Tidal or mangrove forests

Tidal forests grow near the estuaries, swampy margins of islands and along sea coasts. The plants are halophytes characterized by the presence of stilt roots, pneumatophores and viviparous germinations of seed. The common plants are *Rhizophora, Avicennia,* and *Sonneratia.* These are found near sea coast,Gujarat, Ganges, delta regions of Mahanadhi, Godavari, Krishna, Sundarbans and Pulicat, Pichavaram, Ramanathapuram of Tamil Nadu.

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